people of Hindustan,' muttered their disenchanted Padshah, 'have an extraordinary mode of evincing their fidelity', as his entourage continued to be depleted by occasional desertions. When a few months later, he heard that his brother Askari was galloping towards them with 2,000 soldiers, Humayun realized that Hindustan was now lost. Instead of heading to Kandahar, he decided to head for Persia, to seek asylum at the court of Shah Tahmasp.

Regarding the decision to leave Akbar behind in Hindustan, the accounts vary in the details. According to Gulbadan, who would have heard about the events from Hamida Banu herself, the imminent arrival of Askari precipitated such a frenzy that though Khwaja Muazzam and Bairam Khan were able to get Hamida Banu onto a horse to follow Humayun, 'there was not a chink of time in which to take the emperor Jalal-ud-din Muhammad Akbar'. According to Jauhar, who was present at the time, it was Humayun who found it 'requisite' to leave the young prince behind. According to Nizamuddin Ahmad, a court historian of Akbar's who was not present at the event, 'the weather was very hot, so he [Akbar] was left behind'—a somewhat startling declaration given the lateness of the year and the proximity to Kandahar. Abu'l Fazl himself sweepingly assured readers that Humayun would have realized that Akbar was 'under the protection of Divine love'. What is certain is that Humayun rode away to Persia with a very small cortège of some thirty or forty persons, which included only two women, one of whom was Hamida Banu. It seems surprising, given Akbar's tender age, that his mother did not remain with him. The accounts all agree that Humayun summoned Hamida Banu as soon as he realized he would have to ride away and she, as a young bride of only sixteen, may not have felt she had real choice in the matter. But that she may have had conflicted feelings, maybe even regret, about this decision seems to be reflected in the fact that she is the only one to have said, via Gulbadan, that there was such an urgency to leave that it was out of her control that Akbar got left behind.

Akbar had with him the remainder of the Mughal party, including the milk mothers who would always watch over him with such dedicated ferocity that they would even endanger their lives to ensure his safety. Askari arrived at the camp looking for Humayun, but he was told that 'he went hunting long ago'. So Askari ordered that the young Akbar be taken to Kandahar, where he was handed over to the care of Askari's wife, Sultanam Begum, who doted on him.